No Robust Ideology Premium in New York City Home Prices

Fixed-Effects Estimates Reverse Sign With the Measure of Ideology

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Data and Code Availability. The analysis uses public data from the New York City Department of Finance, the Department of City Planning, the Board of Elections, and the City Council. Replication materials, including code for data construction and every reported result, are available to the editors and reviewers on request.

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Use of Large Language Models. We used large language models as writing and coding assistants to polish prose and debug code. All analysis, results, and substantive content are our own.

Abstract

Does a neighborhood's political composition move its home prices? Using 520,365 New York City home sales from 2016 to 2025 and election returns for the city's 51 council districts, we find a positive association in the raw data that is not robust. The one specification that looks sturdy, district fixed effects, reverses sign with the measure of ideology: the estimate is positive for the mayoral two-party Democratic share (0.74), negative for the mayoral all-candidate share (-0.50), and negative for the presidential share (-1.98), each significant under wild cluster bootstrap inference. A placebo that uses only each measure's citywide drift across elections reproduces these signs, and adding sale-year effects removes significance for all three measures. The one pattern that survives for mayoral measures, a positive estimate with borough-by-year effects, disappears when districts are allowed their own price trends and is absent for presidential vote share. A difference-in-differences design around the December 2024 City of Yes housing vote yields a precise null once the pre-period is matched to the post-period (-0.0004; 95% interval -0.035 to 0.034), a close-election instrument is too weak to be informative, and district-level spatial models find no positive association. We also document three pitfalls in using New York City election returns across years: an independent candidate who held 42 percent of the 2025 mayoral vote, election-district boundaries that orphan 18 to 24 percent of earlier votes, and double counting of districts that straddle council lines. We find no robust ideology premium; apparent significance arises from time trends, measurement choices, and spatial clustering.

1 Introduction

Housing in expensive American cities is often described as a political problem. Left-leaning, high-regulation metropolitan areas are blamed for restricting supply, and the same places tend to have the highest prices. If local politics shapes land use, and land use shapes prices, then a neighborhood's political composition should be associated with what its homes sell for. This paper asks whether that association exists within one city, and whether it can be given a causal reading.

New York City is a useful place to ask. Its 51 council districts differ substantially in political composition, council members hold considerable informal authority over rezonings in their districts, and the city has a long, public record of sales and elections. We combine 520,365 property sales between 2016 and 2025, most of them residential, with the Democratic share of the vote in each district in three mayoral and three presidential elections.

Our main finding is negative. We find no ideology premium that is robust to how ideology is measured or how time is controlled. A naive regression produces a large, positive, and apparently precise coefficient. Clustering standard errors at the district level, comparing districts within boroughs, or modeling spatial spillovers each weaken it. One specification, district fixed effects, appears to survive: the estimate is highly significant even under wild cluster bootstrap inference. But its sign depends on the measure. With the mayoral two-party Democratic share it is $+0.74$; with the mayoral all-candidate share it is -0.50; with the presidential share it is -1.98. An effect of ideology on prices should not change sign when we change the way ideology is measured.

The explanation is simple. With district fixed effects and no time controls, the coefficient is identified from changes over time within districts, and there are only three election waves. Each measure has its own citywide drift across waves: the mayoral two-party share jumps in 2025, the mayoral all-candidate share falls, and the presidential share declines steadily. Nominal prices rise throughout. The sign of the estimate simply follows the sign of each measure's drift. A placebo that gives every district the same citywide wave average, and therefore contains no information about ideology differences, reproduces the estimates. Adding sale-year effects removes significance for every measure.

We make three contributions. First, we show that a fixed-effects estimate can be highly significant, survive clustering and a wild bootstrap, and still reflect nothing more than a time trend interacting with measurement, and we provide a simple placebo that diagnoses it. Second, we assess the ideology–price relationship across three measures, six specifications, and two samples, rather than a single preferred model. Third, we document practical pitfalls in building district-level ideology from New York City election returns, which may help others working with these data.

We also test for a causal channel directly. A difference-in-differences design around the City of Yes for Housing Opportunity vote of December 2024 finds no differential price change between districts whose representatives voted for and against the measure once the pre-period is matched to the post-period. A close-election instrument is unidentified in its primary form and too weak to inform when relaxed.

Section 2 reviews related work. Section 3 describes the data and the three ideology measures. Section 4 presents the empirical strategy. Section 5 reports results. Section 6 discusses what the evidence does and does not show, and Section 7 concludes. Further details are in the appendix.

2 Background

The idea that local politics affects housing costs has several roots. In the homevoter hypothesis, homeowners are the most politically engaged residents and use local land-use and fiscal policy to protect the value of their homes (Fischel, 2001). Models of tax capitalization and local public goods imply that the quality and cost of local government are reflected in property values (Tiebout, 1956; Oates, 1969). A large literature links land-use regulation to high prices and to the divergence of prices across metropolitan areas (Glaeser and Gyourko, 2003; Gyourko, Mayer, and Sinai, 2013; Hsieh and Moretti, 2019). Closer to our question, Kahn (2011) finds that more liberal California cities issue fewer housing permits than similar cities in the same metropolitan area, which would push prices up.

Two features complicate any reading of an ideology–price correlation. First, Americans increasingly live near people who share their politics (Bishop and Cushing, 2008; Brown and Enos, 2021), so ideology may proxy for who lives in a place rather than for what its government does. Second, the political divide that matters for housing may not be the partisan one. Einstein, Glick, and Palmer (2019) show that participation in local land-use hearings skews toward older, wealthier residents who oppose new housing regardless of a city's overall partisan lean. For this reason we also study a housing-specific measure of political preference, the council vote on City of Yes.

Our empirical approach draws on three methodological literatures. Inference with a small number of clusters, here 51 districts, is unreliable without correction; we use the cluster-robust methods surveyed by Cameron and Miller (2015) and the wild cluster bootstrap of Cameron, Gelbach, and Miller (2008), with the six-point weights of Webb (2014). Because treatment-like variables in panels are often serially and spatially correlated, standard errors that ignore this are known to overstate significance (Bertrand, Duflo, and Mullainathan, 2004). Finally, rather than reporting one preferred model, we present estimates across many specifications and measures, in the spirit of specification-curve analysis (Simonsohn, Simmons, and Nelson, 2020).

3 Data and Measures

3.1 Sales and property characteristics

Sales come from the New York City Department of Finance's citywide annualized calendar sales file, which contained 845,607 records for 2016 through 2025 at the time of our extract (September 2026). Parcel characteristics come from the Department of City Planning's Primary Land Use Tax Lot Output (PLUTO) file. We keep sales above $10,000, which removes 277,610 records (33 percent), mostly nominal transfers between related parties, and then drop 1,041 exact duplicates, leaving 566,956 sales. Our analysis sample is the 520,365 sales with non-missing values of the controls, and the dependent variable is the log of the nominal sale price. Where specifications also require unit counts, the sample is 355,480 sales. As a robustness check, a restricted sample of 469,697 sales keeps tax-class 1 and 2 properties priced at $100,000 or more and excludes sales that appear to be parts of multi-parcel transactions (Appendix Table A1).

Controls are year built, number of floors, land-use category, and commercial floor-area ratio, plus residential and commercial unit counts where noted. Because the dependent variable is in nominal dollars,

specifications without sale-year effects mix real appreciation and inflation, a point that matters below.

3.2 Three measures of ideology

We construct the Democratic vote share at the election-district level and aggregate to the 51 current council districts. We use three contests, because each has strengths and weaknesses, and we report all three throughout.

- **Mayoral two-party share:** Democratic votes divided by Democratic plus Republican votes in the mayoral general elections of 2017, 2021, and 2025. Votes on the Working Families line count as Democratic and votes on the Conservative line as Republican. This is the most obvious construction and the one we first built.
- **Mayoral all-candidate share:** Democratic votes divided by votes for all candidates.
- **Presidential two-party share:** the same two-party ratio for the 2016, 2020, and 2024 presidential elections.

Each sale is matched to the nearest election: for the mayoral measures, 2016–2018 sales to 2017, 2019–2023 to 2021, and 2024–2025 to 2025; for the presidential measures, 2016–2017 sales to 2016, 2018–2021 to 2020, and 2022–2025 to 2024. Council districts are held fixed at their current boundaries throughout. Ideology therefore takes 153 distinct values (51 districts and three waves), which is the effective amount of variation behind every estimate below.

We regard the presidential share as the cleanest measure. It uses the same two-party contest in every wave and is not distorted by the presence of a major independent candidate. The mayoral measures remain valuable because they reflect local political preferences more directly, so we report them as well.

3.3 Three measurement pitfalls

Constructing these measures from public returns requires three choices that are easy to get wrong and that, we show, matter for interpretation.

An independent candidate in 2025. Candidates on lines other than Democratic, Working Families, Republican, and Conservative held 6.3 percent of candidate-line votes in 2017 and 4.4 percent in 2021, but 42.3 percent in 2025, when a former governor ran on an independent line. A two-party ratio silently discards these votes. The citywide two-party Democratic share in 2025 is 88.4 percent, but the Democratic candidate's share of all candidate-line votes is 51.0 percent. As a result, the mayoral two-party and all-candidate measures move in opposite directions in 2025 (Table 1 and Figure 1).

Election-district boundaries. Election districts were redrawn and combined after the 2020 census. Election-district identifiers in the 2016–2021 returns do not match the current district file for 17.8 to 24.1 percent of candidate votes (17.8 percent in 2016, 23.7 percent in 2017, 24.1 percent in 2020, and 23.8 percent in 2021; 0.5 percent in 2024 and none in 2025). Dropping these votes would give each district's measure a different, non-random subset of its electorate. For 2016–2021 we recover them by overlaying the Department of City Planning's historical election-district boundary files for each period on the current council districts, which brings the loss to zero. For 2024 and 2025 we use the current election-district file, which leaves 0.5 percent of 2024 votes unmatched.

Districts that straddle council lines. Many election districts cross council-district boundaries. Assigning the full vote of such a district to every council district it touches inflates district vote totals by 29 to 31 percent and blends neighboring districts together. We instead apportion each election district's votes across council districts in proportion to area. The resulting measures correlate above 0.96 with the full-assignment versions, so the choice does not change district rankings much, but it matters for spatial statistics: the Moran's I of the mayoral two-party measure falls from 0.57 under the first-built construction to 0.48 with boundary matching and to 0.41 once votes are also apportioned by area.

Our preferred measures use the boundary-matched, area-weighted construction. Results for every variant, including the as-first-built measures and a dominant-district assignment, are in Appendix Table A3 and lead to the same conclusions.

Table 1: Ideology measures and their averages across council districts, by election wave

Measure	Contest	2016/17	2020/21	2024/25	Change
Mayoral two-party	Mayor	0.715	0.709	0.865	+0.150
Mayoral all-candidate	Mayor	0.672	0.677	0.508	−0.164
Presidential two-party	President	0.805	0.764	0.679	−0.125
Mayoral votes on other lines (citywide)		6.3%	4.4%	42.3%	

Notes: Unweighted means across the 51 council districts, using the first-built construction. The mayoral waves are 2017, 2021, and 2025; the presidential waves are 2016, 2020, and 2024. Change is the 2024/25 value minus the 2016/17 value.

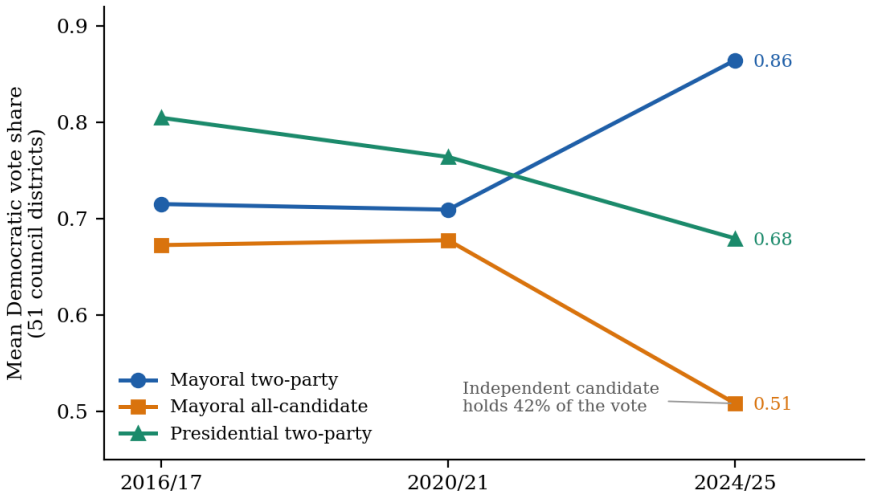


Figure 1: Citywide time paths of the three ideology measures. The mayoral two-party share rises in 2025 because an independent candidate holding 42 percent of the vote is dropped from the denominator; the all-candidate share falls; the presidential share declines steadily.

4 Empirical Strategy

4.1 Specifications

Let y_i be the log sale price of sale i, located in council district $d(i)$ and borough $b(i)$ and occurring in year $t(i)$. Let $I_{d,w}$ be the Democratic vote share in district d in the election wave $w(t)$ matched to year t, and let X_i be the controls. We estimate six specifications that differ in how they use geography and time. The first compares districts within boroughs:

$$y_i = \alpha + \beta\, I_{d(i),w(i)} + X_i'\gamma + \mu_{b(i)} + \varepsilon_i. \tag{1}$$

The second adds district fixed effects α_d, so that β is identified only from changes in ideology over time within districts:

$$y_i = \alpha_{d(i)} + \beta\, I_{d(i),w(i)} + X_i'\gamma + \varepsilon_i. \tag{2}$$

The remaining specifications add time controls. Adding sale-year effects λ_t to equation (2) gives

$$y_i = \alpha_{d(i)} + \lambda_{t(i)} + \beta\, I_{d(i),w(i)} + X_i'\gamma + \varepsilon_i, \tag{3}$$

which compares changes in districts relative to citywide price changes. Replacing λ_t with borough-specific year effects $\lambda_{b(i)t(i)}$ compares districts only with others in the same borough. Adding district-specific linear trends $\delta_d t$ to equation (3),

$$y_i = \alpha_{d(i)} + \lambda_{t(i)} + \delta_{d(i)}\, t(i) + \beta\, I_{d(i),w(i)} + X_i'\gamma + \varepsilon_i, \tag{4}$$

allows each district its own underlying price trajectory. A sixth specification combines borough and sale-year effects without district effects. Together these span the standard menu of fixed-effects designs for a variable that is observed in only three waves.

4.2 Why district fixed effects need a time control

Because $I_{d,w}$ takes only 153 values, the within-district variation that identifies β in equation (2) is variation across waves. It helps to split each observation of ideology into its citywide wave average and the district's deviation from that average:

$$I_{d,w} = \bar{I}_w + \tilde{I}_{d,w}, \qquad \tilde{I}_{d,w} \equiv I_{d,w} - \bar{I}_w. \tag{5}$$

The wave average $\bar{I}_w$ is the same for every district, so it carries no information about ideology differences across places; it simply tracks the passage of time. If prices drift upward over the sample and $\bar{I}_w$ drifts up or down, a regression without time controls will attach a significant coefficient to ideology even if ideology has no effect. We test this directly by estimating equation (2) separately with $\bar{I}_w$ alone (a placebo that contains no cross-district information) and with $\tilde{I}_{d,w}$ alone.

4.3 Inference

Ideology varies at the district-wave level, so we cluster standard errors by council district. With only 51 clusters, conventional cluster-robust p-values can be too small, so we report p-values from a t distribution with 50 degrees of freedom and from a wild cluster bootstrap-t with Webb six-point weights and 9,999 replications. Stars in the tables and intervals in the figures use the bootstrap.

4.4 Spatial models

Prices and ideology are both spatially clustered. At the district level ($N = 51$), we estimate a spatial lag model,

$$p_d = \rho \sum_j w_{dj} p_j + \beta \bar{I}_d + Z_d' \gamma + u_d, \tag{6}$$

and a spatial error model, $p_d = \beta \bar{I}_d + Z_d' \gamma + u_d$ with $u = \lambda W u + \varepsilon$, by maximum likelihood (Anselin, 1988; LeSage and Pace, 2009). Here p_d is the median log price, $\bar{I}_d$ is mean ideology, Z_d are district means of the controls, and W is a row-standardized five-nearest-neighbor weights matrix.

4.5 Quasi-experimental designs

To look for a causal channel, we use two designs. The first is a difference-in-differences design around the City of Yes for Housing Opportunity zoning amendment, adopted by the Council on December 5, 2024 by a vote of 31 to 20. Because the amendment is a citywide text change, a member's vote is a revealed housing-specific preference rather than a district-specific policy, so this is a test of whether preference predicts differential price changes. With Yes_d equal to one for districts whose member voted in favor,

$$y_i = \alpha_{d(i)} + \lambda_{t(i)} + \beta \left(\text{Yes}_{d(i)} \times \text{Post}_{t(i)}\right) + X_i' \gamma + \varepsilon_i, \tag{7}$$

and the event-study version replaces the single interaction with interactions for each period relative to 2022–23. The main specification sets Post = 1 for 2025 and omits 2024, which contains the vote.

The second design uses close council elections as an instrument for ideology, following Lee (2008). The instrument equals one if the district's prior council race was won by a Democrat within a narrow margin and zero if won by a Republican, with races outside the margin excluded. Details are in Appendix C.

5 Results

5.1 The raw association

We begin with the first-built mayoral two-party measure (Table 2). A bivariate regression gives a coefficient of 0.945, which looks large and precise. Adding controls lowers it to 0.615, and adding borough fixed effects lowers it to 0.288, a reduction of roughly 70 percent. In the last column, a ten-point difference in Democratic share is associated with prices about 2.9 percent higher. Borough matters far more: relative to Manhattan,

sales are 0.79 log points lower in the Bronx, 0.63 in Queens, 0.58 in Staten Island, and 0.26 in Brooklyn. Across the 51 districts, the raw correlation between mean ideology and median log price is only 0.175.

Table 2: Baseline regressions of log sale price on the mayoral two-party Democratic share

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Democratic share	0.945	0.615	0.288
Classical standard error	(0.007)	(0.007)	(0.009)
District-clustered standard error			(0.172)
p-value, clustered t / wild bootstrap			0.100 / 0.122
Controls	No	Yes	Yes
Borough fixed effects	No	No	Yes
R^2	0.037	0.104	0.155
Observations	520,365	520,365	520,365

Notes: Dependent variable is log sale price. Democratic share is the first-built mayoral two-party measure. Classical standard errors treat all sales as independent; ideology varies only across 153 district-wave cells.

The classical standard errors in Table 2 are very small because they treat 520,365 sales as independent observations. Clustering by district multiplies the standard error of the last column roughly twentyfold, to 0.172, and moves the p-value from below 0.001 to 0.100 (0.122 under the wild bootstrap). The association is also not stable across measures. In the first row of Table 3, the borough-fixed-effects estimates for the three preferred measures are $+0.17$, -0.10, and -0.15, and none is statistically distinguishable from zero (wild p between 0.36 and 0.60). Even the sign of the cross-sectional association depends on which election is used.

5.2 Fixed effects: a significant estimate that changes sign

District fixed effects are the natural next step, because they remove every time-invariant difference between districts, including housing stock, amenities, and transit. The second row of Table 3 and Figure 2 show the result. The estimate is highly significant for all three measures, and significant under the wild bootstrap at the 1 percent level, but its sign is not constant: $+0.74$ for the mayoral two-party share, -0.50 for the mayoral all-candidate share, and -1.98 for the presidential share. These are not noisy estimates of a common effect. Their 95 percent intervals are $[0.54, 0.93]$, $[-0.83, -0.17]$, and $[-2.28, -1.68]$, which do not overlap.

Table 3: Estimated coefficient on the Democratic vote share across specifications and measures

		Ideology measure		
Specification	N	Mayoral two-party	Mayoral all-candidate	Presidential two-party
Borough FE	520,365	0.173	−0.096	−0.150
		(0.161)	(0.159)	(0.225)
District FE	520,365	0.738***	−0.502***	−1.976***
		(0.085)	(0.164)	(0.143)
Borough + year FE	520,365	0.015	0.012	0.068
		(0.178)	(0.176)	(0.229)
District + year FE	355,480	0.652	0.441	−0.146
		(0.407)	(0.276)	(0.692)
District + borough×year FE	355,480	0.747***	0.540**	−0.029
		(0.285)	(0.210)	(0.518)
District + year FE + district trends	355,480	−0.076	0.088	0.280
		(0.091)	(0.086)	(0.403)

Notes: Each cell is a separate regression of log sale price on the Democratic share, with district-clustered standard errors in parentheses. Measures are boundary-matched and area-weighted. Stars denote wild cluster bootstrap p-values: *** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$. The first three specifications use the 520,365-sale analysis sample; the last three also control for unit counts and use 355,480 sales. All specifications include year built, number of floors, land use, and commercial floor-area ratio. Results for all fifteen measure variants are in Appendix Table A3.

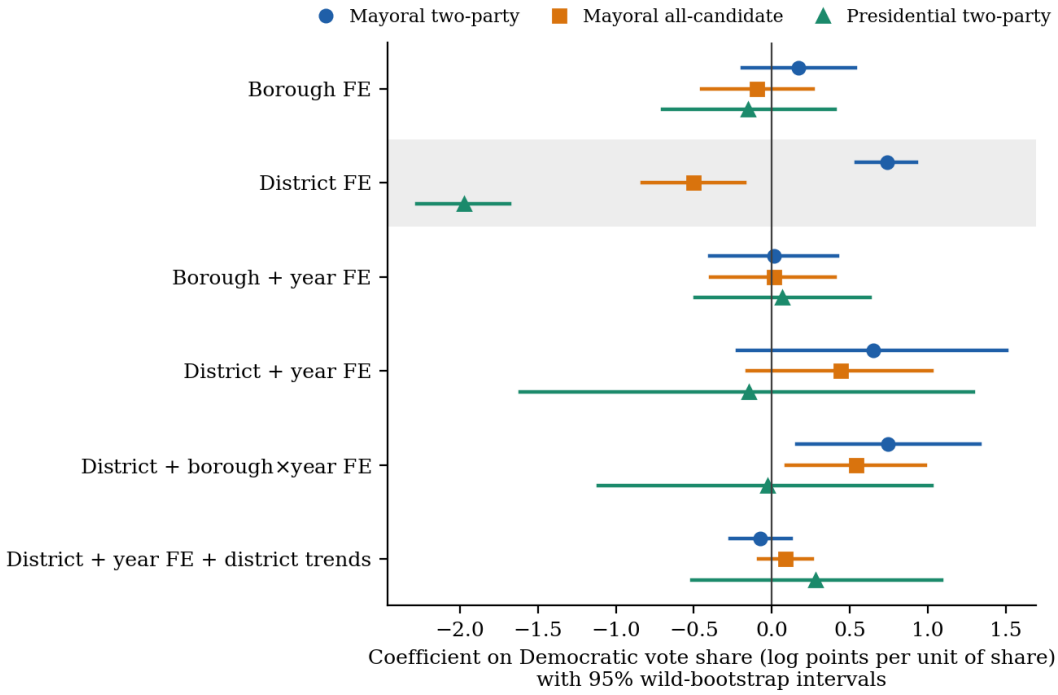


Figure 2: Estimated coefficient on the Democratic vote share by specification and measure, with 95 percent wild-bootstrap intervals. The shaded row marks district fixed effects without time controls, where the sign follows the measure.

5.3 Why the sign follows the measure

Figure 1 suggests the explanation. Across the three election waves, the citywide average of the mayoral two-party share rises, the average of the all-candidate share falls, and the average of the presidential share falls. These drifts have the same signs as the three district-fixed-effects estimates. Over the same years, nominal prices rise. A regression that identifies ideology only from changes over time, and has no control for the passage of time, will pick up that coincidence.

The placebo in equation (5) tests this directly (Table 4 and Figure 3). When we replace each district's ideology with the citywide wave average, which contains no information about differences between districts, the estimates keep the same sign and are similar or larger in magnitude: $+1.22$, -0.99, and -2.15. For the presidential measure the placebo (-2.15) is nearly identical to the actual estimate (-1.98). The district deviations from the wave average, which are the only part that contains information about ideology differences, are positive for all three measures but statistically indistinguishable from zero and imprecisely estimated (0.42, 0.23, and 0.99, with wild intervals that include zero).

Table 4: Decomposing the district-fixed-effects estimate

Measure	Actual district-FE estimate	Citywide wave means only	District deviations
Mayoral two-party	0.738	1.224***	0.423
		(0.114)	(0.250)
		[0.989, 1.450]	[−0.190, 1.017]
Mayoral all-candidate	−0.502	−0.990***	0.227
		(0.093)	(0.202)
		[−1.175, −0.799]	[−0.246, 0.704]
Presidential two-party	−1.976	−2.147***	0.988
		(0.131)	(0.709)
		[−2.416, −1.872]	[−0.568, 2.588]

Notes: Each cell is a regression with district fixed effects, controls, and no year effects. "Citywide wave means only" replaces each district's ideology with the average across districts in its election wave. "District deviations" uses the district's ideology minus that average. Wild-bootstrap 95 percent intervals in brackets; stars denote wild p-values as in Table 3. $N = 520{,}365$.

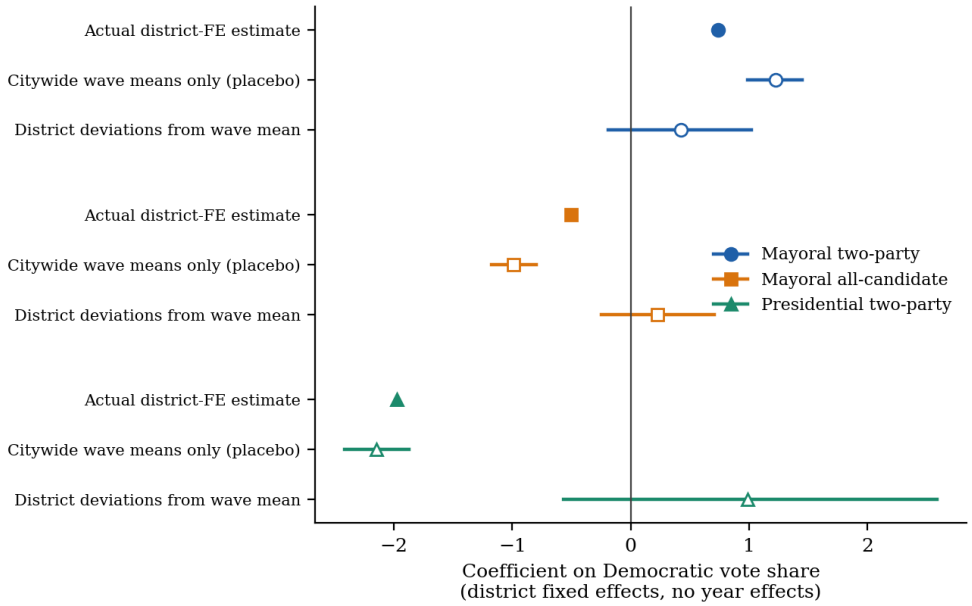


Figure 3: The district-fixed-effects estimate and its two components. The placebo that uses only citywide wave averages reproduces the sign of the actual estimate; the part that varies across districts is imprecise and not significant.

A second check exploits the fact that the mayoral two-party share has almost no citywide drift before 2025 (0.715 in 2017 and 0.709 in 2021). In the sample of sales through 2023 (424,730 sales), where the mayoral share has no common trend, the district-fixed-effects estimate for that measure falls from 0.74 to 0.30 and is not significant (wild $p = 0.81$; Appendix Table A5). The estimate for the presidential share, which trends throughout, stays at -1.77 and remains highly significant. The all-candidate estimate switches sign, from -0.50 in the full sample to $+0.50$, and loses significance. The pattern is what the time-trend explanation predicts: the estimate is significant when the measure has a citywide drift and not otherwise.

5.4 With time controls, almost nothing remains

Equation (3) adds sale-year effects. The district-fixed-effects estimates become small and statistically insignificant for all three measures (Table 3, fourth row: 0.65, 0.44, and -0.15; wild p between 0.16 and 0.85). Comparing boroughs with year effects, the estimates are essentially zero (0.02, 0.01, and 0.07; wild p above 0.8) with intervals narrow enough to rule out effects larger than about 4 to 6 percent for a ten-point difference. Allowing district-specific trends (last row) gives -0.08, 0.09, and 0.28, all insignificant. For the two mayoral measures these are tight: the 95 percent intervals, $[-0.27, 0.12]$ and $[-0.08, 0.26]$, rule out effects larger than about 3 percent for a ten-point change in Democratic share. The presidential interval is much wider, $[-0.51, 1.09]$.

There is one exception, which we report in full. When districts are compared only with other districts in the same borough and year (the fifth row of Table 3), the two mayoral measures yield positive and significant estimates: 0.75 for the two-party share (wild $p = 0.010$) and 0.54 for the all-candidate share ($p = 0.017$). The presidential estimate is -0.03 ($p = 0.95$). The result is not an artifact of the 2025 independent candidate: in the sample through 2023, the estimates are larger, 1.63 and 1.55 (wild $p = 0.013$ and 0.008).

We do not interpret this as evidence of an ideology premium, for three reasons. First, the implied magnitude is implausible: in the sample through 2023, a ten-point increase in the mayoral Democratic share is associated with prices about 0.16 log points higher, more than five times the cross-sectional estimate in Table 2. Second, the estimate disappears when districts are allowed their own price trends (0.04 and 0.16 in the sample through 2023; -0.08 and 0.09 in the full sample), which suggests that it reflects differences in underlying district price trajectories that happen to coincide with changes in mayoral voting. Third, it does not appear for presidential vote share, nor in the housing-vote design below. We cannot say what the mayoral measures capture that the presidential measure does not; candidate-specific coalitions and differing neighborhood price dynamics around the 2021 election are two possibilities. What we can say is that this pattern is not measure-independent, and an effect of ideology should be.

5.5 Robustness

The patterns above hold across alternative samples and constructions. In the restricted sample of 469,697 sales (Appendix Table A4), district fixed effects give $+0.42$, -0.43, and -1.46, year effects again remove significance, and the borough-by-year result is positive for the mayoral measures (0.44 and 0.31) and zero for the presidential measure (0.05). Using the as-first-built measures, boundary matching without area weighting, or a dominant-district assignment changes no conclusion (Appendix Table A3). A hedonic specification that adds log square footage, building-class effects, and tax-class effects is feasible only for the 23,789 sales with complete square-footage data; its estimates are -0.20, 0.33, and -0.28 with standard errors above 1.2 and are uninformative (Appendix Table A6).

5.6 Spatial dependence

Prices and ideology are both strongly clustered in space. Moran's I for the median log price across districts is 0.59 ($z = 7.4$), and for the three ideology measures it is 0.41, 0.41, and 0.45 (z between 5.7 and 6.3; all permutation $p = 0.001$). A naive correlation between two spatially clustered variables is mechanically inflated, which is one reason a significant coefficient in the raw data is not informative.

Table 5 reports district-level regressions of median log price on ideology and district averages of the controls. In the spatial lag model, a district's price depends strongly on its neighbors' prices ($\rho = 0.70$); in the spatial error model the residuals are strongly correlated ($\lambda = 0.81$ for all three measures). In every model with pooled districts, the coefficient on ideology is small and insignificant (p between 0.34 and 0.97 in the spatial models). With borough fixed effects, the OLS coefficient is essentially zero for all three measures (-0.06, -0.06, and -0.02). The spatial error models with borough effects give negative estimates of -0.34 to -0.38 that are marginally significant at the 10 percent level; if anything, they point away from a positive premium.

Table 5: District-level spatial regressions ($N = 51$): coefficient on mean Democratic share

		Pooled districts			With borough fixed effects		
Measure	Moran's I	OLS	Lag	Error	OLS	Lag	Error
Mayoral two-party	0.412	0.136	0.143	0.023	−0.064	−0.104	−0.343*
		(0.211)	(0.151)	(0.193)	(0.191)	(0.161)	(0.184)
Mayoral all-candidate	0.410	0.123	0.136	0.008	−0.058	−0.099	−0.342*
		(0.215)	(0.154)	(0.198)	(0.192)	(0.161)	(0.187)
Presidential two-party	0.446	0.110	0.121	−0.025	−0.024	−0.087	−0.375*
		(0.234)	(0.167)	(0.214)	(0.203)	(0.171)	(0.199)

Notes: Dependent variable is median log price by council district. Controls are district means of year built, number of floors, and commercial floor-area ratio. Weights are row-standardized five-nearest-neighbor. Standard errors in parentheses; * $p < 0.10$ (maximum-likelihood z test). Moran's I for median log price is 0.594. The spatial lag coefficient ρ is 0.70 for pooled districts and 0.46 with borough effects; the spatial error coefficient λ is 0.81 and 0.75 to 0.77.

5.7 The City of Yes vote

The difference-in-differences design in equation (7) gives a first estimate that is positive and statistically insignificant: Yes-voting districts saw prices 0.079 log points higher after the vote than No-voting districts, relative to earlier years (wild $p = 0.143$; Table 6 and Figure 4). The joint test of parallel pre-trends does not reject (Wald $\chi^2(3) = 4.41$, $p = 0.221$), but the event study shows why the estimate is not what it seems. Relative to 2022–23, Yes districts were 14.5 and 12.2 log points cheaper in 2016–17 and 2018–19, a gap that closed steadily before the vote. The 2025 coefficient relative to 2022–23 is -0.006 ($p = 0.80$). The positive headline estimate compares 2025 with an average of all earlier years, including the years in which Yes districts were still catching up.

When the pre-period is matched to the post-period, the estimate vanishes. Using 2022–24 as the comparison period gives -0.0004, with a 95 percent interval of -0.035 to 0.034; using 2022–23 gives -0.009 (-0.045 to 0.026); and allowing district-specific trends in the main design gives -0.015 (-0.095 to 0.067). The first two intervals are narrow: they rule out price differences larger than about 4 percent between districts whose members voted for and against the measure, at the one-year horizon. The interval with district trends is wider, roughly ± 8 percent.

A continuous version of the design, which interacts the presidential Democratic share with the post period, tells the same story. In the 2022–25 window the coefficient is -0.003 (interval -0.065 to 0.057), so a ten-point higher Democratic share is associated with a price change between -0.65 and $+0.57$ percent. With all earlier years as the comparison, the first-built presidential measure gives 0.19 ($p = 0.054$), but that estimate is subject to the same pre-period convergence. Leaving out one borough at a time with the full pre-period gives estimates between 0.02 and 0.18, with the largest, 0.18, when Queens is excluded ($p = 0.02$); all of these use the unmatched pre-period.

This design tests whether a district's revealed housing preference predicts price changes, not whether specific provisions of the zoning change raised prices. It also has a single post-vote year. We therefore read it as showing no evidence of a differential price response at a one-year horizon, not as ruling out slower effects.

Table 6: City of Yes difference-in-differences estimates

Specification	Estimate	Std. error	Wild p	95% interval	N
Yes × Post					
All earlier years as pre-period	0.0793	0.0526	0.143	[−0.025, 0.185]	333,670
Post = 2024–25 (clustered t)	0.0740	0.0499	0.138†	–	355,480
Pre-period limited to 2022–24	−0.0004	0.0182	0.983	[−0.035, 0.034]	93,234
Pre-period limited to 2022–23	−0.0092	0.0183	0.623	[−0.045, 0.026]	71,424
All earlier years, with district trends	−0.0153	0.0390	0.704	[−0.095, 0.067]	333,670
Presidential Democratic share × Post, window 2022–25					
2024 excluded	−0.0030	0.0315	0.925	[−0.065, 0.057]	71,424
2024 as pre-period	0.0127	0.0324	0.703	[−0.049, 0.073]	93,234

Notes: Dependent variable is log sale price. All specifications include district and sale-year fixed effects and controls, with standard errors clustered by district. Yes districts are those whose council member voted for the amendment (31 members; 20 voted No). The main specification omits 2024. Wild-bootstrap p-values and intervals use Webb weights and 9,999 replications. † Clustered t p-value; a bootstrap was not computed for this specification.

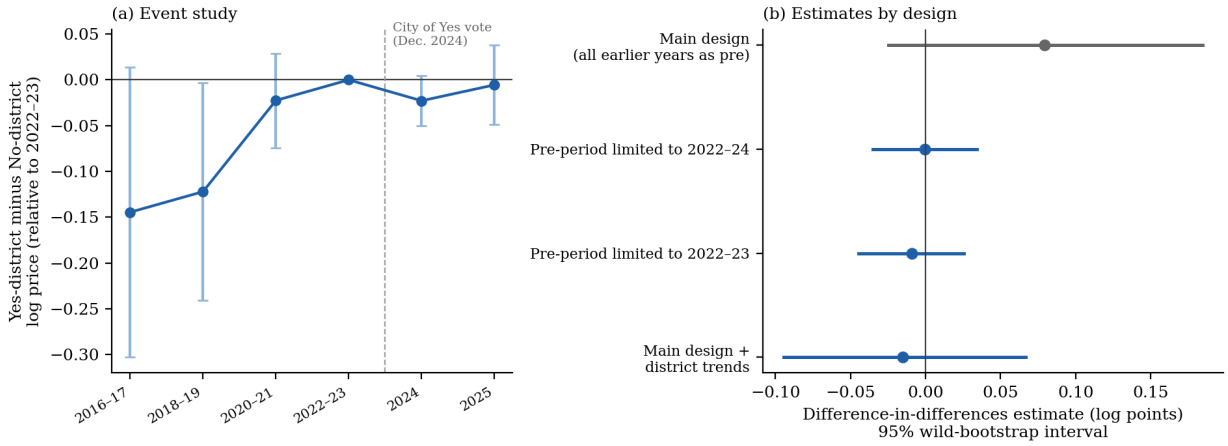


Figure 4: City of Yes. Panel (a): event-study coefficients for Yes-minus-No districts relative to 2022–23, with 95 percent intervals; the gap closes before the vote. Panel (b): estimates for the main design and for designs that limit the pre-period or allow district trends.

5.8 Close-election instrument

The instrument has little to work with. Of 204 council races in 2013, 2017, 2021, and 2025, only 4, 7, 12, and 17 are decided within 5, 10, 15, and 20 points. In the primary specification, with district and year effects, the instrument is collinear with the fixed effects at every bandwidth, so the model is not identified. Relaxing the specification, by using borough effects or bandwidths up to 40 points, identifies six specifications, but none has a first-stage F-statistic above conventional thresholds (the largest is 7.4) and the coefficients range from -14.7 to $+18.3$ (Appendix Table A7). A local-linear version that controls for the margin has first-stage F between 1.6 and 18.1 across bandwidths of 25 to 40 points, but only 11 to 19 clusters and standard errors larger than the estimates. A further limitation is that prior races were held under the pre-2022 council map but are matched to current districts. We regard the instrument as uninformative and draw no conclusion from it.

5.9 Does ideology help predict prices?

Machine-learning models offer a complementary question: does ideology add predictive information beyond location? In our temporal split, models are trained on sales through 2017 and evaluated on 2018. In that sample ideology takes a single value for each of the 51 districts, so it is a deterministic function of district and cannot add information beyond district identity. Consistent with this, adding it to a LightGBM model changes held-out mean absolute error from 0.4418 to 0.4399, about one-twentieth of the gap between that model and a tuned random forest (0.4016). Where the feature is retained, its SHAP importance ranks between 9th and 15th of 25 across five model families (Appendix Table A9). We report these results for completeness; given the collinearity, the ranks do not bear on the causal question.

6 Discussion

6.1 What the evidence shows

Table 7 summarizes the evidence. Three sources of spurious significance run through it. The first is *measurement*: a standard two-party ratio discards 42 percent of the 2025 mayoral vote, boundary changes orphan nearly a quarter of earlier votes, and double counting blends neighboring districts. The second is *time*: with only three election waves, a regression with district effects identifies ideology from each measure's citywide drift, and a placebo built from that drift alone reproduces the estimates. The third is *space*: prices and ideology are both strongly clustered, so a naive correlation is inflated, and once spatial dependence or borough effects are modeled the association is gone.

Table 7: Summary of evidence

Test	Result	Reading
Borough comparison	$+0.17$, -0.10, -0.15; none significant	Sign depends on the measure
District fixed effects	$+0.74$, -0.50, -1.98; all significant	Sign follows each measure's citywide drift
Placebo (wave means only)	Reproduces the sign of the estimate	Estimate reflects time trends
Year effects	Insignificant for all measures	No association once time is controlled
Borough-by-year effects	Positive for mayoral, zero for presidential	Not measure-independent; vanishes with district trends
Spatial models	Insignificant; zero with borough effects	Spatial clustering explains the raw association
City of Yes, matched pre-period	-0.0004 (interval -0.035 to 0.034)	Precise null at one year
Close-election instrument	Unidentified or weak	Uninformative

6.2 What the evidence does not show

We do not claim that ideology has exactly zero effect. Several estimates are imprecise: in the specification with district and year effects the presidential interval runs from -1.6 to 1.3, and the hedonic estimates are

uninformative. The mayoral borough-by-year estimates are positive and significant, and we cannot fully explain them. The City of Yes design is a test of a housing-specific preference proxy over one year. Our conclusion is narrower: there is no estimate of an ideology premium that is robust to the choice of measure and the treatment of time, and the evidence that looks most persuasive on its face is the least reliable.

6.3 Implications

For researchers, the lesson is practical. A fixed-effects estimate on a variable observed in few waves should be accompanied by a placebo that uses only the variable's citywide drift, by estimates with year effects, and by a check that the sign survives a change of measure. Election returns in New York need care: contests with major independent candidates, changing district boundaries, and straddling districts can each distort a district-level measure.

For the policy debate, the evidence is more consistent with an explanation based on location and land-use rules than on political composition itself. Ideology and prices share a geography, because like-minded households cluster (Bishop and Cushing, 2008; Brown and Enos, 2021) and because both vary along the same boundaries, but we find no evidence that the political composition of a district moves its prices independently of that geography.

6.4 Limitations

Several limitations bear on interpretation. First, with three election waves and 51 districts, the effective sample for ideology is small, and tests have limited power against modest effects. Second, we hold council districts fixed at their current boundaries, so earlier ideology refers to the territory now in each district. Third, the dependent variable is in nominal dollars; sale-year effects absorb inflation but specifications without them do not. Fourth, about 6 percent of sales fall outside tax classes 1 and 2 and include some commercial properties; the restricted sample excludes them with similar results. Fifth, the City of Yes design measures a preference proxy with a single post-vote year, and the close-election instrument is weak and mismatched in district vintage. Finally, we study one city, so the patterns may not generalize to other places where political composition varies more within the same housing market.

7 Conclusion

Raw data on New York City home sales show a positive association between a district's Democratic vote share and its prices. We find that this association is not robust. It changes sign across measures of ideology, it disappears when time is controlled, and it is absent in district-level spatial models. The single specification that appears sturdy, district fixed effects, produces estimates of opposite signs for different measures and is reproduced by a placebo containing no information about ideology differences between districts. A difference-in-differences design around the City of Yes vote yields a precise null once its pre-period is matched to the post-period, and a close-election instrument is too weak to inform. In this evidence, the apparent ideology premium reflects time trends, measurement choices, and the shared geography of prices and politics. We therefore find no robust ideology premium in New York City home prices.

A Data and Measurement

Table A1: Construction of the sales samples

Step	Sales remaining	Removed
Raw sales records, 2016–2025	845,607	
Sale price above $10,000	567,997	277,610
Exact duplicates removed	566,956	1,041
Non-missing controls (analysis sample)	520,365	46,591
with unit counts (specifications with year effects)	355,480	
restricted sample: tax class 1 or 2, price $\geq$ $100,000, single parcel	469,697	50,668

Table A2: Election returns: ballot lines, boundary matching, and district assignment

Election	Contest	Candidate-line votes	Other lines	Unmatched ED keys	Full-assignment ratio
2016	President	2,720,629	–	17.8%	1.31
2017	Mayor	1,143,321	6.3%	23.7%	1.29
2020	President	3,034,405	–	24.1%	1.31
2021	Mayor	1,118,245	4.4%	23.8%	1.29
2024	President	2,701,573	–	0.5%	1.31
2025	Mayor	2,182,637	42.3%	0.0%	1.31

Notes: "Other lines" is the share of candidate-line votes outside the Democratic, Working Families, Republican, and Conservative lines. "Unmatched ED keys" is the share of candidate votes whose election-district identifier is absent from the current election-district file; for 2016–2021, matching to historical boundaries recovers all but a handful of votes, and the preferred measures use the current file for 2024 and 2025, which leaves 0.5 percent of 2024 votes unmatched. "Full-assignment ratio" is the sum of council-district votes divided by the actual votes when each election district's full vote is assigned to every council district it touches; area weighting reduces the ratio to 1.00. Citywide, the mayoral Democratic share of two-party votes was 70.9, 70.5, and 88.4 percent in 2017, 2021, and 2025, against 66.5, 67.4, and 51.0 percent of all candidate-line votes.

B Additional Regression Results

Tables A3 to A6 report coefficients on the Democratic vote share with district-clustered standard errors in parentheses and stars for wild-bootstrap p-values (*** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.10$). Controls and sample sizes are as in Table 3 (520,365 sales for the first three specifications, 355,480 for the last three) unless noted.

Table A3: All fifteen measure variants, full sample

Measure	Borough FE	District FE	Borough + year	District + year	District + boro×yr	District trends
Mayoral two-party, as first built	0.288	0.776***	0.067	0.674	0.935***	−0.120
	(0.172)	(0.092)	(0.203)	(0.428)	(0.297)	(0.135)
area-weighted	0.173	0.738***	0.015	0.652	0.747***	−0.076
	(0.161)	(0.085)	(0.178)	(0.407)	(0.285)	(0.091)
boundary-matched	0.205	0.722***	0.032	0.591	0.724**	−0.073
	(0.170)	(0.083)	(0.194)	(0.404)	(0.285)	(0.095)
boundary-matched, area-weighted (preferred)	0.173	0.738***	0.015	0.652	0.747***	−0.076
	(0.161)	(0.085)	(0.178)	(0.407)	(0.285)	(0.091)
boundary-matched, dominant district	0.174	0.738***	0.017	0.651	0.747***	−0.074
	(0.161)	(0.086)	(0.179)	(0.406)	(0.285)	(0.091)
Mayoral all-candidate, as first built	−0.109	−0.547***	0.058	0.429	0.638***	0.089
	(0.163)	(0.148)	(0.194)	(0.286)	(0.200)	(0.103)
area-weighted	−0.096	−0.502***	0.012	0.441	0.540**	0.088
	(0.159)	(0.164)	(0.176)	(0.276)	(0.210)	(0.086)
boundary-matched	−0.098	−0.534***	0.029	0.436	0.578**	0.096
	(0.169)	(0.166)	(0.189)	(0.297)	(0.224)	(0.092)
boundary-matched, area-weighted (preferred)	−0.096	−0.502***	0.012	0.441	0.540**	0.088
	(0.159)	(0.164)	(0.176)	(0.276)	(0.210)	(0.086)
boundary-matched, dominant district	−0.095	−0.503***	0.014	0.443	0.541**	0.089
	(0.159)	(0.164)	(0.176)	(0.276)	(0.211)	(0.086)
Presidential two-party, as first built	−0.193	−1.706***	0.121	−0.387	−0.339	−0.213
	(0.222)	(0.169)	(0.247)	(0.423)	(0.392)	(0.203)
area-weighted	−0.150	−1.976***	0.068	−0.146	−0.029	0.280
	(0.225)	(0.143)	(0.229)	(0.692)	(0.518)	(0.403)
boundary-matched	−0.147	−1.974***	0.106	−0.252	−0.230	0.182
	(0.242)	(0.134)	(0.245)	(0.710)	(0.533)	(0.392)
boundary-matched, area-weighted (preferred)	−0.150	−1.976***	0.068	−0.146	−0.029	0.280
	(0.225)	(0.143)	(0.229)	(0.692)	(0.518)	(0.403)
boundary-matched, dominant district	−0.148	−1.975***	0.069	−0.158	−0.051	0.275
	(0.226)	(0.144)	(0.229)	(0.688)	(0.512)	(0.403)

Notes: "Area-weighted" and "boundary-matched, area-weighted" coincide by construction, because the area-weighted measures use the historical boundaries for 2016–2021 and the current file for 2024–2025. "As first built" assigns each election district in full to every council district it touches and uses the current election-district file. "Boundary-matched" uses historical election-district boundaries. "Area-weighted" apportions votes across council districts by area; "dominant district" assigns each election district to the council district with the largest overlap.

Table A4: Restricted sample (tax class 1 or 2, price $\geq$ \$100,000, single parcel)

Measure	Borough FE	District FE	Borough + year	District + year	District + boro×yr	District trends
Mayoral two-party, as first built	0.223	0.465***	0.072	0.297	0.570***	0.010
	(0.189)	(0.114)	(0.229)	(0.204)	(0.187)	(0.106)
Mayoral two-party, preferred	0.122	0.423***	0.012	0.293	0.442***	0.049
	(0.166)	(0.134)	(0.187)	(0.169)	(0.159)	(0.069)
Mayoral all-candidate, preferred	−0.071	−0.426***	0.012	0.187	0.310**	0.160*
	(0.162)	(0.093)	(0.183)	(0.118)	(0.125)	(0.086)
Presidential two-party, preferred	−0.081	−1.464***	0.076	−0.336	0.051	0.157
	(0.226)	(0.162)	(0.234)	(0.361)	(0.333)	(0.276)

Notes: The first three specifications use 469,697 sales or fewer, depending on missing controls; see Appendix Table A1.

Table A5: Sales through 2023

Measure	Borough FE	District FE	District + year	District + boro×yr	District trends
Mayoral two-party, as first built	0.082	0.094	1.421	2.343***	0.076
	(0.204)	(0.497)	(0.790)	(0.839)	(0.344)
Mayoral two-party, preferred	0.034	0.302	1.281	1.628**	0.040
	(0.177)	(0.394)	(0.654)	(0.576)	(0.280)
Mayoral all-candidate, preferred	0.005	0.502	1.309	1.552***	0.164
	(0.177)	(0.261)	(0.565)	(0.532)	(0.298)
Presidential two-party, preferred	−0.113	−1.774***	−0.374	−0.094	0.588
	(0.225)	(0.158)	(0.674)	(0.496)	(0.349)

Notes: Sample restricted to sales in 2023 or earlier (424,730 sales for the first two columns; 311,033 for the last three). Mayoral measures then include only the 2017 and 2021 waves, for which the mayoral two-party share has no citywide drift.

Table A6: Hedonic specifications

	Full hedonic ($N = 23{,}789$)		Land area and units only ($N = 26{,}308$)	
Measure	Coef. (SE)	Wild p	Coef. (SE)	Wild p
Mayoral two-party	−0.203 (1.226)	0.885	−0.750 (0.630)	0.282
Mayoral all-candidate	0.325 (1.212)	0.822	−0.257 (0.557)	0.687
Presidential two-party	−0.278 (1.969)	0.912	−1.172 (0.796)	0.245

Notes: Both specifications include district and sale-year fixed effects. The full hedonic specification adds log gross and land square footage, unit counts, land-use and building-class categories, and tax-class effects, and requires positive square footage for both, which only 23,789 of 520,365 sales satisfy. The second specification requires only positive land area and adds unit counts (26,308 sales). Standard errors in parentheses are clustered by district.

C Close-Election Instrument

The instrument equals one if a district's prior council race was won by a Democrat within the stated margin of victory and zero if won by a Republican, and districts whose prior race was not close are excluded. Because

ideology varies only at the district-wave level and the instrument at the district-cycle level, the fixed effects can absorb the instrument entirely when few races are close. Table A7 reports all twelve specifications tried, including those that could not be estimated. Table A8 reports a local-linear variant that controls for the margin of victory on each side of zero, estimated with district-clustered covariance.

Table A7: Close-election instrument: all specifications

Fixed effects	Bandwidth	Identified	First-stage F	Coefficient	p
District	±5 pp	No	–	–	–
District	±10 pp	No	–	–	–
District	±15 pp	No	–	–	–
District	±20 pp	No	–	–	–
Borough	±5 pp	No	–	–	–
Borough	±10 pp	No	–	–	–
Borough	±15 pp	Yes	1.04	−14.69	0.321
Borough	±20 pp	Yes	0.59	18.28	0.448
District	±25 pp	Yes	2.44	3.73	0.191
District	±30 pp	Yes	7.40	0.52	0.731
District	±35 pp	Yes	5.13	0.61	0.718
District	±40 pp	Yes	7.30	−0.01	0.992

Notes: Specifications also include sale-year effects and the controls of Table 3, with standard errors clustered by district. "No" means the instrument is exactly collinear with the fixed effects, so no estimate exists. Only 4, 7, 12, and 17 of 204 council races are decided within 5, 10, 15, and 20 points.

Table A8: Local-linear close-election specification

Bandwidth	First-stage F	Coefficient	Std. error	p	Clusters	N
±10 pp		not estimable			5	15,313
±15 pp		not estimable			7	26,514
±20 pp		not estimable			9	37,555
±25 pp	1.64	−1.363	1.423	0.338	11	44,283
±30 pp	12.71	−0.525	1.385	0.704	17	74,390
±35 pp	18.14	−0.330	1.009	0.744	18	85,923
±40 pp	17.89	−0.526	0.742	0.479	19	92,873

Notes: Instruments are the close-race indicator and its interaction with the margin; the margin enters linearly on each side. Standard errors are clustered by district; the small number of clusters makes inference unreliable. Prior council races were held under the pre-2022 district map but are matched to current districts.

D Predictive Models and Counterfactual Simulations

Table A9 reports held-out performance for models trained on sales through 2017 (121,052 sales) and evaluated on 2018 sales (56,723 sales). In this sample ideology is a constant within each council district, so its importance is not separable from district identity. Table A10 reports simulated percentage changes in predicted prices for hypothetical interventions: replacing R3 zoning with R7 and raising residential floor-area ratio by half (upzoning); the reverse with a 30 percent reduction (downzoning); and adding 0.15 to the Democratic share. The ideology scenario is largely extrapolation: in the LightGBM model, 31.6 percent

of shifted observations are capped at 1.0 and 38.3 percent exceed the largest share seen in training. These simulations describe model-implied sensitivities, not causal effects, and magnitudes vary widely across models.

Table A9: Held-out performance and importance of ideology

Model	MAE	R^2	Rank of ideology (of 25)	Mean |SHAP|
Random forest (tuned)	0.4016	0.590	15	0.032
CatBoost	0.4174	0.581	9	0.061
XGBoost	0.4177	0.570	11	0.056
LightGBM, with ideology	0.4399	0.543	11	0.047
LightGBM, without ideology	0.4418	0.535	–	–
Ridge	0.6293	0.179	11	0.014
Elastic net	0.6313	0.177	excluded by penalty	0.000

Notes: MAE is mean absolute error in log-price units. Importance is mean absolute SHAP value (Lundberg and Lee, 2017), exact for each model family.

Table A10: Simulated mean percentage change in predicted price

Model	Upzoning	Downzoning	Democratic share +0.15
Random forest (tuned)	+0.58	−0.38	−2.85
CatBoost	+6.33	−1.30	−8.53
XGBoost	+10.57	−1.02	−11.00
LightGBM, with ideology	+4.62	−1.06	−8.51
LightGBM, without ideology	+4.72	−0.97	0.00
Ridge	+4.28	−2.77	−1.10
Elastic net	+4.68	−3.02	0.00

Notes: Means across the 51 council districts. Models without an ideology input, or with a zero coefficient on it, return exactly zero for the ideology scenario by construction.

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